

05 | OVERVIEW



Accessing Climate and Science Discourse: Digital Platforms and Community Standards

Abstract

Many climate scientists share their research directly with the public through online platforms such as The Conversation. This lesson uses the author page of climate scientist Kevin Trenberth and the platform's community standards to explore how readers can find trustworthy science online, judge an author's expertise, and take part in respectful debate about climate change.

Introduction

Where do you go when you want to understand climate science? Increasingly, researchers write for the public on platforms where readers can comment and respond. The Conversation is one such site, publishing articles written by academics. Its author pages list each writer's position, experience, and research areas, so readers can see who is behind the words. Kevin Trenberth, a Distinguished Scholar at the National Center for Atmospheric Research (NCAR) and honorary affiliate faculty at the University of Auckland, has written for the platform since 2012. His profile, and the rules that govern reader comments, offer a window into how public science discussion is designed to work.

How Do Scientists Study This?

This lesson treats a scientist's author page and a platform's community standards as evidence to analyze. First, students examine the credentials listed on Trenberth's profile: his doctoral degree in meteorology from MIT (1972), his decades at NCAR, his work with the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC) and the World Climate Research Programme, and his publication record. Second, they read The Conversation's community standards, which welcome debate and dissent but prohibit personal attacks, abuse, defamatory language, and deliberate disruption. Finally, students connect the two: how does knowing an author's expertise, and knowing the rules for discussion, help readers weigh claims and disagree productively?

Judging climate science online



Check the author

Look at an author's position, training, research areas, and publications to judge their expertise on a topic.

Read the rules

Community standards explain what kinds of comments are welcome and what behavior will not be tolerated.

Weigh the claims

Combine expertise, evidence, and respectful debate to decide how much to trust what you read online.

What Did They Discover?

Trenberth's profile shows deep expertise in climate variability and change. He has published over 295 refereed journal articles and more than 630 publications, and he is one of the most highly cited scientists in geophysics. He was heavily engaged in the IPCC, which shared the 2007 Nobel Peace Prize, and he chaired the Global Energy and Water Exchanges (GEWEX) program. His honors include the American Geophysical Union's 2013 Climate Communication Prize, recognizing his work explaining science to the public. The Conversation's standards state that it welcomes debate and dissent, but not personal attacks on authors, users, or any individual, and it aims to be an inviting space for intelligent discussion.

An author profile by the numbers

295+

refereed journal articles by Kevin Trenberth

630+

total publications

2012

year he joined The Conversation as an author

The standards separate disagreement with ideas, which is welcome, from attacks on people, which are not. That distinction is the core of healthy scientific debate.

Takeaways

Know your source

An author's training, research record, and affiliations help readers judge expertise.

Debate ideas

Good platforms welcome dissent about evidence while banning personal attacks and abuse.

Scientists communicate

Leading researchers share findings publicly, and communication itself is valued in science.

Key Terms

Credentials

Qualifications such as degrees, positions, and publications that show a person's expertise in a field.

Refereed (peer-reviewed) article

A research paper checked by independent experts before it is published in a scientific journal.

Community standards

Rules a platform sets for how users may behave, such as banning abuse or harassment.

Dissent

Disagreement with a widely held view. In science, dissent should be backed by evidence and argued respectfully.

IPCC

The Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change, a United Nations body that assesses published climate research for policymakers.

Words to Know · Accessing Climate and Science Discourse

Credentials

Refereed (peer-reviewed) article

Community standards

Dissent

IPCC

Activity

Comment Section Moderators

Students act as moderators for a climate article and decide which sample comments follow the community standards.

Materials: Printed set of sample comments prepared by the teacher; Copy of the community standards summary; Sorting mat: approve, edit, remove

1. Read the community standards summary as a class and list what is welcomed and what is not tolerated.
2. In pairs, sort each sample comment into approve, ask the writer to edit, or remove.
3. For every comment you remove, name the specific rule it breaks.
4. Rewrite one removed comment so it keeps the disagreement but follows the standards.
5. Discuss: how do author credentials and comment rules each help readers judge what is trustworthy?

References

The Conversation. Kevin Trenberth author profile and community standards.
<https://theconversation.com/profiles/kevin-trenberth-15259>